

He is not a billionaire bleeding heart in a frantic quest of God's brownie points. Nor is he a guilt-ridden moneybag attempting to display his golden heart. He is just a middle-class farmer of Kilinjar village in Kasargode, who derives inexplicable joy by building houses free-of-cost for the poor. For this 71-year-old, it all began one day in 1995

the home MAKER

✱ **K.N. Gopalakrishna Bhat, 71**

Project Driven by an urge to help the homeless, he uses his own savings to build houses for them

Can-do Icon Grandfather Subbaraya Bhat, who taught him the value of serving the poor



According to an Action Aid report, India has about **78 million** homeless people

when his childhood friend Kundian, a poor Dalit labourer, came rushing to him. His hut had been washed away in a rainstorm and he needed help to rebuild it. K.N. Gopalakrishna Bhat felt he had no choice but to give him his savings, Rs 10,000, which he had kept aside for a pilgrimage to Kashi. "It made me think that instead of giving money to more Kundians to repair their homes, it would be better if I built concrete ones for them. This is how the project was born. Since then I have never felt an urge to go to Kashi," he says.

Bhat, who has so far donated 148 houses, is also known as "swami" for providing astrological tips to villagers who come to him to seek solutions to their quotidian problems—like a fisherwoman who calls

him because she is not selling much. Bhat immediately makes some calculations and asks her to "wait for 20 minutes". By then all her fish is sold out. He doesn't know how he is able to make such accurate predictions. "It just comes to my mind." And where does he get money to build houses? Bhat mostly uses his own, whatever he saves by selling the output from his 25-acre land, about Rs 10-15 lakh annually, and also from donations from those who seek his astrological advice.

Charity begins at home and now Bhat's eldest son Krishna, 50, a local panchayat member, selects the beneficiaries who may be "homeless and without a regular income, but own a piece of land". "We receive scores of applications, but we choose people only after proper inspection," says Krishna. Their reward? Beneficiaries like Majirulla Mohini. "For us, he's God," she says. For Bhat, it's enough reason to live.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

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I believe 'manava seva' is 'madhava seva' (serving fellow beings is serving God).

K.N. GOPALAKRISHNA BHAT, Social worker

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